

THEME 9 · B1+/B2

Unusual Lives

9A Off-the-Grid — giving information briefly, referring to different times, living/working conditions

9B Strange to Say — unconventional and off-grid lifestyles

Warm-up

Look at the title: Unusual Lives. What do you think we will talk about in this theme?
Tell your partner two ideas.

VOCABULARY

New words

20 target words

off-grid

adj.



şebekeden bağımsız

Their off-grid cabin runs entirely on solar panels and a wood stove.

self-sufficient

adj.



kendi kendine yetebilen

After five years on the land, the family is almost completely self-sufficient.

digital nomad

n. phrase



dijital göçebe

As a digital nomad, she has worked from twelve different countries this year.

wilderness

n.



vahşı doğa, ıssız bölge

They spent their first winter in a cabin deep in the wilderness.

isolated

adj.



izole, تنها

The lighthouse stands on an isolated rock, miles from the nearest village.

homestead

v.



kendi toprağına yerleşip geçimini sağlamak

They decided to homestead a small plot of land after leaving their office jobs.

sustainable

adj.



sürdürülebilir

The community grows food using sustainable methods that don't exhaust the soil.

solitude

n.



yalnızlık, inzivâ

He says he chose the mountains for the solitude, not to escape people.

nomadic

adj.



göçebe

Their nomadic lifestyle means they rarely stay in one country for more than a season.

commune

n.



ortak yaşam topluluğu, komün

The commune has grown from four members to almost forty in a decade.

thrive

v.



gelişmek, serpilmek

Surprisingly, the children seem to thrive without television or city noise.

downsize

v.



küçültmek, sadeleştirmek

They downsized from a four-bedroom house to a small camper van.

subsistence

n.



geçimlik (yaşamını sürdürecekt kadar)

Subsistence farming provides exactly what the family needs, with almost nothing left over.

eccentric

adj.



eksantrik, alışılmadık

Locals describe him as eccentric, but harmless and endlessly curious.

hermit

n.



münzevi, inzivaya çekilmiş kişi

The old hermit has lived in that valley for over thirty years.

livelihood

n.



geçim kaynağı

Beekeeping became her main livelihood after she left the city.

adapt

v.



uyum sağlamak

It took the family almost a year to adapt to life without electricity.

unconventional

adj.



alışılmadık, sıra dışı

Living on a converted boat is a fairly unconventional choice for a family of five.

remote

adj.



uzak, ıssız

The village is so remote that the nearest shop is a two-hour walk away.

resourceful

adj.



becerikli, çareyi bulan

You have to be extremely resourceful to fix everything yourself, miles from any town.

Quick game · What's the word?

“dijital göçebe”

a homestead

b subsistence

c digital nomad

Quick game · What's the word?

“becerikli, çareyi bulan”

a remote

b unconventional

c resourceful

Quick game · What's the word?

“ortak yaşam topluluğu, komün”

a remote

b downsize

c commune

Quick game · What's the word?

“vahŧi dođa, issız b3lge”

a wilderness

b eccentric

c downsize

Quick game · What's the word?

“geçimlik (yaşamını sürdürecekt kadar)”

a digital nomad

b solitude

c subsistence

Quick game · What's the word?

“sürdürülebilir”

a downsize

b adapt

c sustainable

GRAMMAR

Mixed Conditionals: Linking a Past Decision to a Present Situation

Notice

If she **hadn't moved** to the mountains ten years ago, she wouldn't be living this simply now.

If he **hadn't given up** his office job, he wouldn't be growing his own vegetables today.

They wouldn't own this cabin now if they **hadn't taken** the risk five years ago.

If she **hadn't inherited** the family land, would she be living this unconventional life today?

In each sentence, does the 'if' part refer to the past or the present? What about the result?

Complete the rule

Complete the rule with the words in the box.

the past

the present

would/wouldn't + base verb

had/hadn't + past participle

Complete the rule

In a mixed conditional like this, the 'if' clause refers to _____ ,
and uses _____ .

✓ the past / had/hadn't + past participle

Complete the rule

The result clause refers to _____, and uses _____.

✓ the present / would/wouldn't + base verb

The rule

Mixed conditionals connect a past decision or action to a present situation. The 'if' clause refers to the past (had/hadn't + past participle); the result clause refers to the present (would/wouldn't + base verb).

TR Mixed conditionals (karışık koşul cümleleri), geçmişteki bir kararın şimdiki bir durum üzerindeki etkisini anlatmak için kullanılır. 'If' cümlecğinde geçmişte atıfta bulunmak için 'had/hadn't + past participle' kullanılır; sonuç cümlecğinde ise şimdiki zamana atıfta bulunmak için 'would/wouldn't + base verb' kullanılır.

When? We use this structure to talk about how a past decision — such as moving, leaving a job, or choosing a lifestyle — still affects someone's present living conditions.

TR Geçmişte alınan bir kararın (taşınma, bir işten ayrılma, bir yaşam biçimi seçme gibi) bugünkü yaşam koşulları üzerindeki etkisini anlatırken bu yapıyı kullanırız.

Build sentences · Example

she + not move to the countryside +

she / not know how to grow vegetables now

If she hadn't moved to the countryside, she wouldn't know how to grow vegetables now.

Build sentences

he

+

not leave his office job

+

he / not have this much free time now

If he hadn't left his office job, he wouldn't have this much free time now.

Build sentences

they

+

not build their own cabin

+

they / not be living rent-free today

If they hadn't built their own cabin, they wouldn't be living rent-free today.

Build sentences

she + not learn to fish and forage +

she / not survive alone in the forest now

If she hadn't learned to fish and forage, she wouldn't survive alone in the forest now.

Build sentences

we

+

not decide to downsize

+

we / not feel this free now

If we hadn't decided to downsize, we wouldn't feel this free now.

Build sentences

? / she + not inherit the family land +

she / live this unconventional life today

If she hadn't inherited the family land, would she be living this unconventional life today?

Your turn

Write four mixed conditional sentences about your own life, or about someone you know who made an unusual choice, linking a past decision to a present situation.

If I hadn't...

If my family hadn't...

She wouldn't be... now if...

We wouldn't have... today if...

Form

POSITIVE

If she hadn't moved off-grid, she wouldn't be living this simply now.

If he hadn't taken the risk, he wouldn't own this land today.

NEGATIVE

If they hadn't downsized, they wouldn't feel this free now.

If we hadn't left the city, we wouldn't be growing our own food today.

QUESTION

Would you be living differently now if you had made a different choice?

If she hadn't inherited the land, would she be doing this today?

SHORT ANSWERS

Yes, I would. / No, I wouldn't.

Yes, she would. / No, she wouldn't.

Error detective

If she didn't move to the mountains, she wouldn't be living this simply now.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ If she hadn't moved to the mountains, she wouldn't be living this simply now.

Error detective

If he hadn't left his job, he won't have this free time today.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If he hadn't left his job, he wouldn't have this free time today.**

Error detective

If they hadn't downsized, they wouldn't have felt this free now.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If they hadn't downsized, they wouldn't feel this free now.**

A • Choose the correct option.

If he _____ his city job, he wouldn't be living off-grid now.

a hadn't left

b didn't leave

c hasn't left

A • Choose the correct option.

If she hadn't inherited the land, she _____ this unconventional life today.

a wouldn't be living

b won't live

c didn't live

A • Choose the correct option.

_____ you be living this way now if you had made a different choice ten years ago?

a Would

b Will

c Did

B · Complete with the correct form.

If we _____ (not decide) to downsize, we wouldn't feel this free now.

✓ hadn't decided

B · Complete with the correct form.

She _____ (not survive) alone in the wilderness now if she hadn't learned to forage.

✓ **wouldn't survive**

B · Complete with the correct form.

If he _____ (not take up) beekeeping, he wouldn't have this unusual livelihood today.

✓ **hadn't taken up**

C · Judge the sentence.

If she didn't move to the forest, she wouldn't be living this way now.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **If she hadn't moved to the forest, she wouldn't be living this way now.**

C · Judge the sentence.

If they hadn't sold their house, they wouldn't be travelling full-time today.

a Correct

b Incorrect

C · Judge the sentence.

If he hadn't left the city, he wouldn't have this much freedom now.

a Correct

b Incorrect

Dialogue · Complete with the correct form.

A: _____ you _____ (choose) this life if you could go back and decide again?

✓ Would / choose

Dialogue · Complete with the correct form.

B: If I _____ (not try) it once, I _____ (never / know) how much I'd love it.

✓ hadn't tried / would never have known

Dialogue · Reorder the sentence.

living / this / be / wouldn't / simply / she / now

now

she

wouldn't

living

this

simply

be

•

✓ **She wouldn't be living this simply now.**

GRAMMAR

Relative Clauses: Describing Unusual People, Places and Lifestyles

Notice

A digital nomad is someone **who** works online while travelling the world.

The valley, **which** has no roads or electricity, is home to just three families.

This is the cabin **where** the family spent their first off-grid winter.

Elena, **whose** entire house runs on solar power, hasn't paid an electricity bill in years.

In which sentence does the relative clause give extra, non-essential information (with commas), and in which sentences is it essential to identify who or what we mean?

Complete the rule

Complete the rule with the words in the box.

defining (no commas, essential)

non-defining (with commas, extra info)

who/that

which/that

where

whose

Complete the rule

A relative clause that is essential to identify the person or thing is called _____.

✓ defining (no commas, essential)

Complete the rule

A relative clause that adds extra, non-essential information, and can be removed, is called _____.

✓ non-defining (with commas, extra info)

Complete the rule

We use _____ for people, _____ for things, _____ for places, and _____ for possession.

✓ **who/that / which/that / where / whose**

The rule

Defining relative clauses (who, which, where, whose, that) are essential to identify who or what we mean and are not separated by commas. Non-defining relative clauses add extra information, are separated by commas, can be removed without changing the core meaning, and never use 'that'.

TR Defining relative clause'lar (who, which, where, whose, that), kimden ya da neyden bahsettiğimizi belirlemek için gereklidir ve virgülle ayrılmaz. Non-defining relative clause'lar ise ekstra bilgi verir, virgülle ayrılır ve cümleden çıkarılabilir; bu tür cümlelerde 'that' kullanılmaz.

When? We use relative clauses to identify or add extra information about people, places or lifestyles.

TR İnsanları, yerleri ya da yaşam tarzlarını tanımlarken ya da hakkında ek bilgi verirken relative clause kullanırız.

Build sentences · Example

A hermit is a person.

+

This person chooses to live alone.

A hermit is a person who chooses to live alone.

Build sentences

Mira built her own house from recycled materials. +

Mira now teaches other people to do the same.

Mira, who built her own house from recycled materials, now teaches other people to do the same.

Build sentences

The commune grows all of its own food. +

The commune has around forty members.

The commune, which grows all of its own food, has around forty members.

Build sentences

This is the mountain hut.

+

The family spent three winters there.

This is the mountain hut where the family spent three winters.

Build sentences

Tomas gave up his salary to become a shepherd. +

Tomas's flock now provides everything his family needs.

**Tomas, whose flock now provides everything his family needs,
gave up his salary to become a shepherd.**

Build sentences

? / Do you know anyone. +

This person has chosen an unconventional lifestyle.

Do you know anyone who has chosen an unconventional lifestyle?

Your turn

Write four sentences describing unusual people, places or lifestyles using relative clauses (who, which, where, whose).

A digital nomad is someone who...

I'd love to visit a place where...

I know someone whose...

An off-grid home is a house which...

Form

POSITIVE

A hermit is someone who lives alone, away from other people.
The valley, which has no roads, can only be reached on foot.

NEGATIVE

This isn't a lifestyle which everyone could manage.
He doesn't live in a place where phones even work.

QUESTION

Do you know anyone whose life is completely off-grid?
Is this the cabin where they spent the winter?

SHORT ANSWERS

Yes, I do. / No, I don't.
Yes, it is. / No, it isn't.

Error detective

A digital nomad is someone which works online.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **A digital nomad is someone who works online.**

Error detective

The valley, that has no roads, is very isolated.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **The valley, which has no roads, is very isolated.**

Error detective

This is the cabin which they spent their first winter.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **This is the cabin where they spent their first winter.**

A • Choose the correct option.

A hermit is a person _____ chooses to live completely alone.

a who

b which

c where

A • Choose the correct option.

This is the forest _____ she has lived for the last decade.

a who

b which

c where

A • Choose the correct option.

Elif, _____ house runs entirely on solar power, never pays an electricity bill.

a who

b whose

c which

B · Complete with the correct relative pronoun.

A digital nomad is someone _____ can work from anywhere in the world.

✓ **who**

B · Complete with the correct relative pronoun.

Do you know anyone _____ lifestyle is completely off-grid?

✓ whose

B · Complete with the correct relative pronoun.

This is the valley _____ they built their first cabin.

✓ where

C · Judge the sentence.

A shepherd is someone which lives a simple, outdoor life.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **A shepherd is someone who lives a simple, outdoor life.**

C · Judge the sentence.

The island, which has no roads, is only reachable by boat.

a Correct

b Incorrect

C · Judge the sentence.

This is the hut that they spent their first winter.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **This is the hut where they spent their first winter.**

Dialogue · Complete with who/which/where/whose.

A: Do you know anyone _____ has chosen to live completely off-grid?

✓ **who**

Dialogue · Complete with who/which/where/whose.

**B: Yes — my aunt. She lives in a cabin _____ she built herself,
in a forest _____ almost no tourists go.**

✓ **which / where**

Dialogue · Reorder the sentence.

alone / lives / who / person / a / is / hermit / a

a

alone

a

lives

who

hermit

person

is

.

✓ **A hermit is a person who lives alone.**

READING

The Family Who Left the Grid

Before you read

1. Look at the title. What do you think it means to 'leave the grid'?
2. What do you imagine would be the hardest part of producing your own food and electricity?

THE FAMILY WHO LEFT THE GRID · 1 / 3

Six years ago, Aylin and her husband sold their flat in the city, bought four hectares of rocky hillside, and moved into a tent while they built a house with their own hands. If they hadn't made that decision, they would still be commuting two hours a day and paying rent they could barely afford. Today they grow almost all of their own vegetables, keep chickens and goats, and generate their own electricity from a small solar array on the roof.

THE FAMILY WHO LEFT THE GRID · 2 / 3

Life off-grid is not simply a romantic escape, however. Aylin describes the first winter as brutal: pipes froze, the solar panels produced almost no power on cloudy days, and there were weeks when the nearest working shop felt impossibly far away. 'We had to become resourceful fast,' she says. 'If we hadn't learned to fix things ourselves, we wouldn't have survived that winter.' Slowly, through trial and error, the family adapted.

THE FAMILY WHO LEFT THE GRID · 3 / 3

What surprises visitors most is not the hardship but how ordinary the family's days now feel. Aylin no longer misses her old commute, and her children, who grew up thinking every home has running water on tap, now understand exactly where their food and power come from. 'People ask if we regret it,' she says. 'Honestly, if we hadn't taken the risk, I don't think we'd be half as happy as we are now.'

While you read

What is the main idea of the text?

a Off-grid living is easy and has no real difficulties.

b A family's decision to live off-grid was hard at times but has ultimately made them happier and more self-sufficient.

c The family regrets leaving the city and plans to move back.

While you read

The family bought four hectares of hillside and lived in a _____ while they built their house.

✓ **tent**

While you read

According to the text, what was especially difficult during the first winter?

a The children refused to help with the animals.

b Pipes froze and the solar panels produced little power.

c The local council tried to stop them building.

While you read

According to the text, Aylin says the family regrets taking the risk of moving off-grid.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ According to the text, Aylin says they would not be as happy now if they hadn't taken the risk.

While you read

Aylin's children now understand exactly where their food and _____ come from.

✓ **power**

After you read

1. Do you think you could adapt to a life like Aylin's? Why or why not?
2. What would you miss most if you moved somewhere completely off-grid?

READING

The Keeper of the Last Light

Before you read

1. What do you already know about the job of a lighthouse keeper?
2. Do you think isolated jobs like this still exist today? Where?

THE KEEPER OF THE LAST LIGHT · 1 / 3

On a narrow rock eighteen kilometres from the nearest coastline stands a lighthouse where Meltem has spent every summer for the past nine years. She is one of the very few keepers left whose job hasn't been fully replaced by automatic lights and remote sensors. For four months at a time, her only regular company is the sound of the wind, the occasional passing ship, and a radio link to the mainland.

THE KEEPER OF THE LAST LIGHT · 2 / 3

The work itself is precise and demanding: checking the lamp mechanism, logging weather conditions, and keeping meticulous records that shipping companies still rely on. 'People imagine I just sit and read novels all day,' Meltem laughs, 'but a lighthouse that isn't properly maintained is a lighthouse that eventually fails — and ships depend on that light.' Supplies arrive by boat once a fortnight, weather permitting; when storms close in, they simply don't arrive.

THE KEEPER OF THE LAST LIGHT · 3 / 3

What keeps Meltem returning each year is not tradition alone. She describes a quality of attention that isolated life demands — noticing the smallest change in the sky, the tide, the sound of the generator — that she has never found anywhere else. 'In the city, I moved through my days without really seeing them,' she explains. 'Out here, on a rock where almost nothing changes quickly, I finally learned to pay attention.'

While you read

What is unusual about Meltem's job, according to the text?

a She is one of the few remaining lighthouse keepers whose job hasn't been fully automated.

b She only works one week a year.

c She shares the lighthouse with dozens of other keepers.

While you read

Meltem's lighthouse stands on a narrow rock _____ kilometres from the coastline.

✓ **eighteen**

While you read

According to the text, Meltem says her job mainly involves sitting and reading novels.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ According to the text, Meltem says the job involves precise, demanding work such as checking the lamp and logging conditions.

While you read

How often do supplies normally arrive at the lighthouse?

a Every day

b Once a fortnight,
weather permitting

c Only once a year

While you read

Meltem says that on the rock, she finally learned to pay

_____ •

✓ **attention**

After you read

1. Why do you think Meltem keeps returning to such an isolated job every year?
2. Would you be able to cope with four months of near-total isolation? Why or why not?

LISTENING

Three Years Without Wi-Fi

Before you listen

1. Predict: what do you think Sena might say she misses most, and what she doesn't miss at all?

Three Years Without Wi-Fi

Ses kaydı yakında — transkripti öğretmen okuyabilir.

While you listen

How does Sena get her water and electricity?

a

From the mains, like a normal house.

b

From solar panels and a well.

c

She doesn't use electricity or water at all.

While you listen

Sena says she wouldn't appreciate hot showers as much if she _____ moved to the village.

✓ **hadn't**

While you listen

Sena says she feels very lonely living off-grid.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ Sena says she isn't really lonely, partly because the solitude is part of why she stayed.

While you listen

What does Sena say would be true if she hadn't taken her first trip to the village?

a She would still be living in her old flat.

b She would be even more resourceful than now.

c She would have moved somewhere even more remote.

LISTENING

A Life Between Countries

Before you listen

1. What do you predict a 'digital nomad' does for work, and how might their daily routine be different from yours?

A Life Between Countries

Ses kaydı yakında — transkripti öğretmen okuyabilir.

While you listen

What is the main topic of Kaan's presentation?

a

A relative who works as a lighthouse keeper

b

A cousin who became a digital nomad

c

A traditional off-grid farming community

While you listen

Kaan's cousin has worked from Portugal, Georgia, and a converted _____ in the countryside.

✓ **train carriage**

While you listen

According to Kaan, his cousin's clients insist that she works from one fixed office.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ According to Kaan, her clients don't care where she is, as long as the work is done on time.

While you listen

What does Kaan say is one of the difficulties of his cousin's lifestyle?

a Making real friends
while constantly
moving

b Finding clients who will
pay her

c Getting permission
from her old company

SPEAKING

Could You Live Off-Grid?

In pairs, discuss whether you could live an off-grid or nomadic lifestyle. Talk about at least two unconventional lifestyles from this theme, using mixed conditionals and relative clauses where natural.

SPEAKING

Presenting an Unusual Life

Prepare a two-minute talk about a real or invented person who lives an unconventional life (off-grid, nomadic, isolated, or otherwise unusual). Explain what their life involves, how it's different from a conventional one, and why it appeals — or doesn't appeal — to you.

WRITING

Unconventional Lives Magazine Article

Write a short magazine article about a real or invented person who lives an unconventional or off-grid lifestyle. Start with a clear topic sentence, add at least three supporting sentences with details and examples, and finish with a concluding sentence.

WRITING

A Week in an Unconventional Life

Imagine you have chosen an unconventional lifestyle from this theme (off-grid, nomadic, isolated). Write a descriptive diary entry about a typical day, describing your surroundings, your routine, and how your life compares with your life before.

REVIEW

Exit ticket

Exit ticket

After losing her job, Sena decided to become completely

_____ .

a self-sufficient

b isolated

c eccentric

Exit ticket

A person who works online while travelling from place to place is called a _____ .

a hermit

b digital nomad

c commune

Exit ticket

If she _____ (not move) to the mountains, she wouldn't be living this simply now.

✓ hadn't moved

Exit ticket

A hermit is a person _____ chooses to live completely alone.

✓ who

Exit ticket

This is the cabin _____ the family spent their first off-grid winter.

a who

b which

c where

Exit ticket

If he didn't leave his office job, he wouldn't be growing his own vegetables today.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ If he hadn't left his office job, he wouldn't be growing his own vegetables today.

Exit ticket

Elena, _____ entire house runs on solar power, hasn't paid an electricity bill in years.

✓ whose

Exit ticket

Which sentence correctly links a past decision to a present situation?

a If they didn't downsize, they wouldn't feel this free now.

b If they hadn't downsized, they wouldn't feel this free now.

c If they hadn't downsized, they wouldn't have felt this free now.

Exit ticket

Which word describes someone unusual in an interesting, harmless way?

a eccentric

b sustainable

c nomadic

Exit ticket

Meltem works as a lighthouse keeper, one of the few jobs that still relies on human _____.

✓ attention

Exit ticket

Put the words in order.

is

person

a

a

hermit

alone

lives

who

•

✓ **A hermit is a person who lives alone.**

Exit ticket

The valley, that has no roads, is very isolated.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ **The valley, which has no roads, is very isolated.**

Exit ticket

Rewrite using a mixed conditional.

(She moved off-grid ten years ago. Because of that, she lives this simply now.)

✓ **If she hadn't moved off-grid ten years ago, she wouldn't be living this simply now.**

Exit ticket

Do you know anyone _____ has chosen to live completely off-grid?

✓ who